

WETLANDS: A QUIETLY DISAPPEARING FLOOD DEFENCE ASSET

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What Are Wetlands?

Wetlands refer to areas where water covers the land permanently or seasonally. They include marshes, swamps, lagoons, floodplains, mangroves, and estuaries – covering 6% of the world's land surface and supporting around 40% of all plant and animal species.

Research suggests that major sub-Saharan metropolitan areas are losing 2% to 3% of their total wetland coverage every single year. The increasing destruction of wetlands through land reclamation, unplanned urban development, waste disposal, pollution, sand mining, and agricultural expansion has greatly reduced their ability to protect communities from flooding. As wetlands disappear, rainwater has fewer places to collect naturally, leading to more frequent and severe floods that damage homes, roads, businesses, and essential infrastructure.



Wetlands Are Not Wastelands

Protecting and **restoring** wetlands is one of the most effective and cost-efficient nature-based solutions for building climate-resilient cities and communities. Conserving wetlands require stronger enforcement against illegal encroachment, the integration of wetlands into urban planning and flood management, and meaningful participation of local communities, especially women and young people, in conservation efforts.